

Identifying Presentation Purposes

Cited from *Business Communication I: Essential Skills for Workplace Success P94-P98*

Presentations can have one of two general purposes: *to inform* or *to persuade*. When speaking with an informative purpose, you present the facts. Informative speakers act as teachers relaying information. When speaking with a persuasive purpose, you are acting as an advocate or making an argument. Your role is to advocate for or against something. In some situations, you'll be trying to persuade the audience simply to agree or disagree with an idea—this is known as passive agreement.

In other situations, you'll be trying to persuade the audience to take some sort of action—this is known as active agreement or a call to action.

Determining your purpose may seem like a simple enough task, but speakers with professional excellence always think carefully when determining their purpose. For example, you may need to inform employees about a new policy in your organization. Ask yourself, "Am I merely informing them about the policy, or am I persuading them to follow the new policy?" In all likelihood, you will be persuading them. Although many presentation opportunities appear informative on the surface, a closer look reveals the need or opportunity to persuade. Let's look at another example. Say you're relaying some information on customer satisfaction scores. Are you simply presenting the information, or is there a secondary purpose? If the scores are low, the secondary purpose may be persuading your team that they need to do a better job the next time around. If the scores are high, it may be to celebrate as a team, acknowledge some outstanding performances, motivate team members to keep up the good work, or all of the above.

Specific Purpose

Once you've identified the general purpose of your presentation, you'll begin to formulate a specific purpose. The specific purpose is to an oral presentation what a thesis statement is to an essay. A specific purpose is a declarative sentence telling the listeners what you want them to understand, know, or believe by the end of your presentation.

The following are some examples of specific purposes:

- *I want my employees to understand and follow the new overtime rule.
- *I want the executive team to believe our department deserves a 10% budget increase.
- *I want Company X to select us as the health care provider for its employees.
- *I want my team to feel recognized and appreciated for their hard work.

Designing a presentation is not a linear process in which you move from one step to the next. Instead, designing a presentation is a fluid process. Thus, you may develop a tentative specific purpose and then change it after you have done some analysis and research. In fact, identifying the general and specific purposes for any presentation opportunity will require you to analyze the audience and the context.

Speaking to Inform

As noted earlier, when speaking with an informative purpose, your goal is to present the facts. Informative speakers act as teachers relaying information, striving to be objective and not influenced

or affected by emotions or their individual point of view.

According to Aristotle, a good persuasive speech includes three persuasive appeals: ethos, logos, and pathos. Although Aristotle discussed these appeals in relationship to persuasive presentations, we believe the first two appeals also are important for designing an effective informative presentation.

Ethos

Ethos refers to your credibility as a presenter as well as the credibility of the information delivered in your presentation. To present with professional excellence, you must demonstrate credibility and help your audience believe you and the information or argument you are presenting. Quintilian, a Roman philosopher and educator, viewed credibility as central to any effective rhetoric, which he defined as “a good man speaking well.” The word good in Quintilian’s quote refers to credibility.

How do you establish credibility? According to Aristotle, presenters must demonstrate ethos or positive character by demonstrating competence, trustworthiness, and goodwill. There are many ways to develop positive character within your presentation, but you must make sure the audience is aware of your expertise and knowledge on the subject matter. In addition, you must conduct research and then cite your sources.

Eileen is the vice president of security for a large resort chain. She’s been invited to inform hotel managers about the effectiveness of their new security system at the annual retreat. When Eileen is introduced, both her title and her 15 years with the company are mentioned. This begins to develop her credibility. Within the body of her presentation, Eileen discusses a new security plan that was tested recently at one of the resorts in the chain. When discussing the success of the new plan, she cites improved security scores at that resort and emphasizes that the scores were gathered by an outside agency. By making certain that both she and her data are credible, she has succeeded in establishing ethos.

Logos

Logos is another type of appeal needed in effective presentations. Logos is a term that refers to the words of a presentation in the context of organizational structure and the supporting information. When developing an informative presentation, think of yourself as a teacher laying out information about a particular topic. After reviewing your research and analyzing the purpose, audience, and context, you will develop a clear organizational structure for your presentation (we discuss this in Chapter 9). However, that structure can’t stand without support. The research that you’ve

conducted will become that support. Together, the structure and the information will provide your audience with logical appeal.

What type of research should you include? Obviously, that will depend on the nature of your topic, your purpose, the audience, and the context. However, any or all of the following may have a place in your presentation: definitions, examples, statistics, and quotes. (See Figure 8.1)

When it comes to selecting supporting material for your presentations, remember to include a variety. A statistic revealing that your customer base has declined by 25% is powerful, but supporting that stat with an example from a customer who left is stronger because it adds human interest.

Figure 8.1

Supporting Material

TYPE OF RESEARCH	SUPPORTING MATERIAL
Definitions	Provide explanations of words or concepts that your listeners need to understand
Examples	Provide your listeners with illustrations, parallel cases, or representations of a larger group
Statistics	Provide your listeners with numerical data that are used to analyze, interpret, or explain ideas in your speech
Quotes	Provide your listeners with insight from experts in the field or people who have had firsthand experience with the subject matter

Speaking to Persuade

When giving a persuasive speech, you are acting as an advocate or making an argument. Your role is to advocate for or against something. As noted earlier, you will be trying to persuade the audience either simply to agree or disagree with an idea (passive agreement) or to take some sort of action (active agreement or a call to action). Unlike the informative speaker, the persuasive speaker is subjective, influenced, or affected by individual emotions, biases, or points of view.

Aristotle discussed the three persuasive appeals noted earlier in relationship to persuasive presentations. Let's explore each in relationship to your persuasive speeches.

Again, **ethos** refers to your credibility as a presenter as well as the credibility of the information shared in your presentation. To present with professional excellence, you must demonstrate credibility and help your audience believe you and the information or argument you are presenting. O'Keefe found that the more credibility you have with an audience, the more you will be able to persuade them. This may be the case, but the sad truth is that most of the messages you hear all day,

every day,are void of any type of credibility.Advertisements make claims that come from“leading scientists,”but the scientists are never named.People running for high-ranking political offices throw facts,quotes,and figures around in debates.The information each side presents often contradicts the other side,yet sources are lacking.To speak with professional excellence,you must rise above this common shortcoming and make sure you establish credibility.Remember to be extremely careful when using the internet to conduct research.

How do you establish credibility in a persuasive speech?Just as you would in an informative speech,make certain the audience is aware of your expertise and knowledge on the subject matter.Additionally,cite your sources and make certain the sources are credible.When persuading,it is also important to establish common ground with your audience.That is,show how you have a shared interest,concern,or background.If your audience believes that you share their attitude toward a topic,it increases your ability to persuade them.

Logos,as you should recall,refers to the organizational structure and the supporting information found in your speeches.When developing a persuasive presentation,think of yourself as an attorney making an argument.You’re building a case with your presentation.In Chapter 10,we will discuss ways to organize your persuasive speeches.

Pathos

The final type of persuasive appeal(after ethos and logos)is **pathos**—a term that refers to emotional appeal.Because informative speeches are objective,emotional appeals should not be present in informative speeches.However,pathos is very powerful,and it does play an important role when persuading with professional excellence.But beware—a presentation that has strong pathos but lacks ethos and/or logos is not effective.Far too many presenters rely solely on emotional appeal.In the moment,they may move an audience,but in the long run,the lack of credibility and logic make for a poor presentation.To achieve professional excellence as a presenter,you must include all three appeals(ethos,logos,and pathos)in your presentations.

Vocabulary

序号	英文词汇	中文释义	例句
1	persuasive (adj.)	有说服力的	A persuasive argument backed by data is far more likely to shift corporate policy.
2	informative (adj.)	可提供信息的	The report offers an informative overview of supply chain disruptions across Europe.
3	advocate (n.)	倡导者; 支持者	She is a leading advocate for stricter corporate governance standards.
4	tentative (adj.)	暂定的; 试探性的	The two sides reached a tentative agreement on tariff reductions last month.
5	competence (n.)	能力; 胜任力	Leadership requires both technical competence and strong emotional intelligence.
6	goodwill (n.)	商誉; 善意	The merger valued the brand's goodwill at more than \$100 million.
7	rhetoric (n.)	修辞; 言辞	Political rhetoric rarely translates into real economic reform.
8	bias (n.)	偏见; 倾向性	Confirmation bias can distort decision-making at the executive level.
9	formulate (v.)	制定; 构想	The board will formulate a new strategy to expand into Southeast Asia.
10	declarative (adj.)	陈述的	A clear declarative statement helps align teams around a common goal.
11	linear (adj.)	线性的; 循序的	Economic recovery is rarely linear and often includes unexpected setbacks.

序号	英文词汇	中文释义	例句
12	fluid (adj.)	灵活的; 多变的	Market conditions remain fluid amid shifting interest rate expectations.
13	appeal (n.)	感染力; 诉求	Ethical branding adds strong emotional appeal to consumer products.
14	contradict (v.)	与... 矛盾	New data contradicts earlier claims about productivity growth.
15	acknowledge (v.)	承认; 致谢	Investors acknowledge that risks are rising in the tech sector.
16	motivate (v.)	激励; 激发	Financial rewards alone are not enough to motivate long-term employee loyalty.
17	executive (n.)	高管; 行政人员	Senior executives must balance short-term profits and long-term sustainability.
18	in all likelihood	极有可能; 十有八九	In all likelihood, interest rates will stay high this year.
19	common ground	共同立场; 共识	Negotiators struggled to find common ground on trade rules.
20	rise above	克服; 超越 (不足 / 困境)	Leaders must rise above short-term pressures to plan for the future.

Vocabulary Exercise

Part I Complete the following paragraph with the most suitable words from the box.

advocate, linear, fluid, appeal, in all likelihood, goodwill, tentative

Business presentations serve two core purposes: to inform and to persuade. An informative speaker conveys facts fairly and focuses on clarity, while a persuasive speaker acts as a(n) (1)_____ for a certain idea or position. Unlike a fixed routine, the process of planning a speech is not (2)_____ but highly (3)_____, as presenters often refine their messages after analyzing the audience and situation. To connect with listeners effectively, speakers must build emotional (4)_____ and set aside personal prejudice. (5)_____, a well-defined purpose and reliable content will decide whether the presentation achieves its goal.

Part II Choose the best synonym for the underlined word in each sentence.

1. Effective public speakers formulate concise and purposeful statements before addressing an audience.

- A. construe B. fabricate C. articulate D. perpetuate

2. Insightful organizational leaders strive to motivate team members toward ambitious goals rather than merely managing daily tasks and behaviors.

- A. galvanize B. supervise C. scrutinize D. relinquish

3. Top corporate executives are entrusted with navigating complex market shifts and making far-reaching strategic choices that shape the entire firm's future.

- A. partners B. managers C. customers D. Employees

4. Disciplined and professional presenters consciously rise above personal prejudice to maintain intellectual neutrality in formal discourse.

- A. transcend B. confront C. adhere to D. succumb to

5. Rigorously collected empirical data and contemporary studies frequently contradict long-held conventional assumptions about effective workplace communication.

- A. refute B. substantiate C. augment D. clarify

Part III Translate the following paragraph into English, using the words or expressions given.

优秀的商务演讲人既要展现扎实的专业能力，也要勇于承认自身认知的局限性。他们运用恰当的言辞传递观点，避免因个人偏见干扰判断，积极与听众寻求共识。唯有保持客观理性，演讲才能真实可信，从而实现高效的职场沟通。

(competence, acknowledge, rhetoric, bias, common ground)

Part IV Discussion Questions

1. Why is it important to distinguish between passive agreement and active agreement when planning a persuasive presentation?
2. What might happen if a speaker only focuses on emotional appeal (pathos) but ignores credibility (ethos) and logic (logos) in a business presentation?
3. It is natural for a speaker to face an audience with sharply different opinions. What practical strategies can help a presenter establish common ground and reduce resistance in this situation?
4. Speakers often use data and stories to strengthen their points, but mixing them poorly can confuse or overwhelm listeners. How can they combine statistics and examples effectively to make their message more convincing without information overload?
5. Many people think informative presentations should be completely neutral, but in reality few workplace presentations are truly free of persuasion. How should speakers ethically balance information delivery and subtle persuasion without misleading the audience?